



SOC 201 - Lecture notes 1-13

elements of sociology (Federal University Oye-Ekiti)



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IS SOCIOLOGY A SCIENCE?

What is Science?

Science (from Latin *scientia*, meaning "knowledge") is a systematic enterprise that builds and organizes knowledge in the form of testable explanations and predictions about the universe.

1. Ely Chinoy (1967) in his book titled, "*Society*" sees science as anybody of knowledge based upon reliable observations and organized into a system of general propositions or laws. It can also be defined as the methods by which systematic and accurate knowledge about the "real" world is acquired (Chinoy, 1967:4). The advanced Learner's Oxford Dictionary defined science as the study of the structure and behavior of the physical and natural world and society especially through observation and experiment. Science, according to social science Encyclopedia is said to be concerned with observation, description, definition, classification, measurement, experimentation, generalization, explanation, prediction, evaluation and control of the world (:84).
2. Mark (1993) in his book *Foundations of Social Science Researches* argued that careful observation, hypothesis formulation, experimentation, verification and theory formulation as characteristics of science.
3. The Webster's New Collegiate Dictionary, defines science as knowledge attained through study or practice," or "knowledge covering general truths of the operation of general laws, especially as obtained and tested through scientific method and concerned with the physical world. This definition makes science to look passive as if all scientific discovery, fact or ideas have been completely exhausted and there is nothing new to learn again but certainly this is not what science is, rather it is a dynamic activity that is ever expanding, where new discovery are made every day and new facts are emerging to enrich what we have already known. There are other definitions of science and this will be explained as follows:
4. Science can be defined as a method of quantifying the world by applying the principles of the scientific method, which consist of making empirical observations, proposing hypotheses to explain those observations, and testing those hypotheses in valid and

reliable ways. Furthermore science is the study of the material universe or physical reality in order to understand it. This is done by making observations and collecting data about natural events and conditions, then organizing and explaining them with hypotheses, theories, models, laws, and principles. Also science can be the study of a particular branch of either the process of study or the body of knowledge, such as astronomy, biology, chemistry, geology, and physics. Etc.

5. Science can be defined as systematic pursuit of knowledge following careful rules of research, going on to be faithful to facts and cautious of conclusions. (Baines 1974, Aluko, 2014) asserted that science is the most elaborate and systematic of all forms of knowledge and the least anthropomorphic, in many ways it is the easiest of all forms of knowledge, and it is assessable and far most unconstrained by norms of secrecy or restricted access.

The Webster's 1913 Dictionary defined science with this parenthesis:

- Science is knowledge; knowledge of principles and causes; ascertained truth of facts.
- Science is the accumulated and established knowledge, which has been systematized and formulated with reference to the discovery of general truths or the operation of general laws; knowledge classified and made available in work, life, or the search for truth; comprehensive, profound, or philosophical knowledge. Especially, such knowledge when it relates to the physical world and its phenomena, the nature, constitution, and forces of matter, the qualities and functions of living tissues, etc.; -- called also {natural science}, and {physical science}.
- Science is any branch or department of systematized knowledge considered as a distinct field of investigation or object of study; as, the science of astronomy, of chemistry, or of mind. Studies have shown that the ancient's reckoned seven sciences, namely, grammar, rhetoric, logic, arithmetic, music, geometry, and astronomy; -- the first three being included in the Trivium, the remaining four in the Quadrivium.

Is Sociology a Science?

Characteristics of science

Conclusions of science are reliable, though tentative.

Science is always a work in progress, and its conclusions are always tentative. But just as the word "theory" means something special to the scientist, so too does the word "tentative." Science's conclusions are not tentative in the sense that they are temporary until the real answer comes along. Scientific conclusions are well founded in their factual content and thinking and are tentative only in the sense that all ideas are open to scrutiny. In science, the tentativeness of ideas such as the nature of atoms, cells, stars or the history of the Earth refers to the willingness of scientists to modify their ideas as new evidence appears.

Science is not democratic

Scientific ideas are subject to scrutiny from near and far, but nobody ever takes a vote. If the question of plate tectonics had been decided democratically when it was first presented in the early twentieth century, we would, today, have no explanation for the origins of much of Earth's terrain. Scientific ideas are accepted or rejected instead on the basis of evidence.

Science is non-dogmatic.

Nothing in the scientific enterprise or literature requires belief. To ask someone to accept ideas purely on faith, even when these ideas are expressed by "experts," is unscientific. While science must make some assumptions, such as the idea that we can trust our senses, explanations and conclusions are accepted only to the degree that they are well founded and continue to stand up to scrutiny.

Science cannot make moral or aesthetic decisions.

Scientists can infer the relationships of flowering plants from their anatomy, DNA, and fossils, but they cannot scientifically assert that a rose is prettier than a daisy. Being human, scientists make moral and aesthetic judgments and choices, as do all citizens of our planet, but such decisions are not part of science

Some of the scholars that contributed to the science of sociology among others are: Comte (He sorted the human effort to begin in stages, **theological (God/gods), metaphysical (seeing**

society as natural) and scientific {modern science via the works of scientists eg Isaac Newton etc}), Herbert Spenser, Henri Saint Simon, Emile Durkheim etc

To Auguste Comte positivism is an epistemological position that emerged in combination with sociology, which would eventually develop into a full-fledged academic discipline concerned with the social problems generated by capitalist industrialization, urbanization, and other aspects of contemporary daily life.

Positivism is a logical system that bases knowledge on direct systematic observation, it usually seeks out law like statement in social life that can be tested.

Positivist sociologists apply science to the study of the society in much way that natural science investigate the social world, the use of scientific means is to gather empirical evidence, the major element of positivist investigation is:

Unity Science Hypothesis: this is the claim that whether natural or social science, they all share a common method. This claim has some number of aspects:

- i. **Science like sociology causally explains:** that is regular patterns between events are studied (positivism) and also underlying causal connections between phenomenon are identified (realism)
- ii. **The idea of objectivity:** The idea of objectivity is the removal of personal value or bias in the course of sociological study, a sociologist must report and explain social phenomenon the exact way they are, objectivity in research is the care adherence to the principle of science.
- iii. **Value freedom:** Science provides knowledge of facts i.e. of what is not ought to be, while most science can tell us the most efficient way of achieving our ends, it cannot tell us what those ends should be. The positivist school of thought regarded the sociology as a scientific discipline.

Robert King Merton (1910-2003): he was of the structural functionalist school, and a positivist who originated the sociology of science, he saw science as the emerging in 17th century after the protestant ethics, and suggested that science developed on its own 'ethos', with a distinctive culture and community, he studied science on four basis:

- **Universalism:** Science should be guided by the search for wider, universal truths and should not be biased.
- **Communalism:** Scientist should believe in the earlier findings of science as a common heritage
- **Disinterestedness:** Scientist should be impartial and should subject their work to rigorous examination by their scientific peers
- **Organised Scepticism:** Scientist should suspend judgement till facts in, they should engage in detached scrutiny of beliefs in terms of empirical and logical criteria (Merton, 1936).

SOCIAL STRUCTURE

Social structure, in sociology, the distinctive, stable arrangement of institutions whereby human beings in a society interact and live together. Social structure is often treated together with the concept of social change, which deals with the forces that change the social structure and the organization of society.

Although it is generally agreed that the term *social structure* refers to regularities in social life, its application is inconsistent. For example, the term is sometimes wrongly applied when other concepts such as custom, tradition, role, or norm would be more accurate.

Studies of social structure attempt to explain such matters as integration and trends in inequality. In the study of these phenomena, sociologists analyze organizations, social categories (such as age groups), or rates (such as of crime or birth). This approach, sometimes called formal sociology, does not refer directly to individual behaviour or interpersonal interaction. Therefore, the study of social structure is not considered a behavioral science; at this level, the analysis is too abstract. It is a step removed from the consideration of concrete human behaviour, even though the phenomena studied in social structure result from humans responding to each other and to their environments. Those who study social structure do, however, follow an empirical (observational) approach to research, methodology, and epistemology.

Social structure is sometimes defined simply as patterned social relations—those regular and repetitive aspects of the interactions between the members of a given social entity. Even on this

descriptive level, the concept is highly abstract: it selects only certain elements from ongoing social activities. The larger the social entity considered, the more abstract the concept tends to be. For this reason, the social structure of a small group is generally more closely related to the daily activities of its individual members than is the social structure of a larger society. In the study of larger social groups, the problem of selection is acute: much depends on what is included as components of the social structure. Various theories offer different solutions to this problem of determining the primary characteristics of a social group.

Before these different theoretical views can be discussed, however, some remarks must be made on the general aspects of the social structure of any society. Social life is structured along the dimensions of time and space. Specific social activities take place at specific times, and time is divided into periods that are connected with the rhythms of social life—the routines of the day, the month, and the year. Specific social activities are also organized at specific places; particular places, for instance, are designated for such activities as working, worshiping, eating, and sleeping. Territorial boundaries delineate these places and are defined by rules of property that determine the use and possession of scarce goods. Additionally, in any society there is a more or less regular division of labour. Yet another universal structural characteristic of human societies is the regulation of violence. All violence is a potentially disruptive force; at the same time, it is a means of coercion and coordination of activities. Human beings have formed political units, such as nations, within which the use of violence is strictly regulated and which, at the same time, are organized for the use of violence against outside groups.

Furthermore, in any society there are arrangements within the structure for sexual reproduction and the care and education of the young. These arrangements take the form partly of kinship and marriage relations. Finally, systems of symbolic communication, particularly language, structure the interactions between the members of any society. (

William Form and Nico Wilterdink, 2020).

SOCIAL STRATIFICATION

Definition of Social Stratification

Social stratification is a term used in the social sciences to describe the relative social position of persons in a given social group, category, geographical region or other social unit. It derives from the Latin *strātum* (plural *strata*; parallel, horizontal layers) referring to a given society's

categorization of its people into rankings of socioeconomic tiers based on factors like wealth, income, social status, occupation and power. In modern Western societies, stratification is often broadly classified into three major divisions of social class: upper class, middle class, and lower class. Each of these classes can be further subdivided into smaller classes e.g. "upper middle", ([Saunders Peter, 1990](#)). Social strata may also be delineated on the basis of kinship ties or caste relations.

Persell (1987), define social stratification as the fairly permanent ranking of positions in a society in terms of unequal power, prestige, or privileges. It also refers to a patterned, or structured, social inequalities among whole categories of people, not just among individuals.

Social stratification (see Grusky, [2001](#); Hout & DiPrete, [2006](#); Sørensen, [1986](#)) refers to the fact that all known societies are characterized by a systematic ranking of people or groups of people, this ranking being associated with unequal distribution of resources ([social inequalities](#)), and access to life chances. Systems of social stratification require some form of legitimation to be stable.

Furthermore, social stratification is a particular form of social inequality. All societies arrange their members in terms of superiority, inferiority and equality. Stratification is a process of interaction or differentiation whereby some people come to rank higher than others.

In one word, when individuals and groups are ranked, according to some commonly accepted basis of valuation in a hierarchy of status levels based upon the inequality of social positions, social stratification occurs. Social stratification means division of society into different strata or layers. It involves a hierarchy of social groups. Members of a particular layer have a common identity. They have a similar life style.

The stratification of society is also based upon either an open, or closed, system.

Open System: Status is achieved through merit, and effort. This is sometimes known as a meritocracy. Here people can move from one stratum to another. In many societies, people are divided theoretically into different social classes. The UK is a relatively open society, although disadvantaged groups within society face a glass ceiling.

Closed System: A stratification system is considered closed to the extent that it is difficult, if not impossible to move up the social hierarchy. Status here, is ascribed, rather than achieved. Ascribed status can be based upon several factors, such as family background (e.g. the feudal system consists of landowners and serfs). Political factors may also play a role (e.g. societies organised on the basis of communism), as can ethnicity (e.g. the former apartheid regime in South Africa) and religion.

Types of Social Stratification:

Max Weber further added two aspects of stratification, which were "status" and "power". Status refers to the social position of an individual. Social stratification defines the hierarchical structures of class and status in a society. It forms the larger power structure that influences all the social activities within that particular community. The major types of stratification are: (i) Caste (ii) Class (iii) Estate and (iv) Slavery

(i) Caste is a hereditary endogamous social group in which a person's rank and its accompanying rights and obligations are ascribed on the basis of his birth into a particular group. For example- Brahmins, Kshyatriyas, Vaishyas and Sudra Caste.

(ii) Class-Stratification on the basis of class is dominant in modern society. In this, a person's position depends to a very great extent upon achievement and his ability to use to advantage the inborn characteristics and wealth that he may possess.

(iii) Estate system of medieval Europe provides another system of stratification which gave much emphasis to birth as well as to wealth and possessions. Each estate had a state.

(iv) Slavery had economic basis. In slavery, every slave had his master to whom he was subjected. The master's power over the slave was unlimited.

Characteristics of Social Stratification:

On the basis of the analysis of the different definitions given by eminent scholars, social stratification may have the following characteristics.

(a) Social stratification is universal: There is no society on this world which is free from stratification. Modern stratification differs from stratification of primitive societies. It is a worldwide phenomenon. According to Sorokin “all permanently organized groups are stratified.”

(b) Stratification is social: It is true that biological qualities do not determine one’s superiority and inferiority. Factors like age, sex, intelligence as well as strength often contribute as the basis on which statuses are distinguished. But one’s education, property, power, experience, character, personality etc. are found to be more important than biological qualities. Hence, stratification is social by nature.

(c) It is ancient: Stratification system is very old. It was present even in the small wandering bonds. In almost all the ancient civilizations, the differences between the rich and poor, humble and powerful existed. During the period of Plato and Kautilya even emphasis was given to political, social and economic inequalities.

(d) It is in diverse forms: The forms of stratification is not uniform in all the societies. In the modern world class, caste and estate are the general forms of stratification. In India a special type of stratification in the form of caste is found. The ancient Aryas were divided into four varnas: the Brahmins, Kshatriyas, Vaishyas and Sudras. The ancient Greeks were divided into freemen and slaves and the ancient Romans were divided into the patricians and the plebeians. So every society, past or present, big or small is characterized by diversified forms of social stratification.

(e) Social stratification is Consequential:

Social stratification has two important consequences one is “life chances” and the other one is “life style”. A class system not only affects the “life- chances” of the individuals but also their “life style”.

(f). Gender: Differentiating between men and women is a very intrinsic feature of all kinds of stratification. Women are treated differently from men with respect to their rights and duties in patriarchal societies. The kind of exposure to the world outside home, and the degree of independence they have depends upon the belief systems and culture of a society. Also, women belonging to different strata within the same society follow different norms. So, gender assumes a very dynamic role in shaping the characteristics of a given strata, irrespective of the stratification systems and the cultural differences within.

(g). Inequality: The benefits and opportunities that individuals get are not the same for everyone

as an equal member of the society. Different rewards and remuneration itself marks differences in who gets what and how easily. Status and prestige are two facets of any stratified society that establish inequality among its members. The rich and wealthy enjoy many perks and privileges. The intellectuals earn reverence due to their talent. Higher social position in the hierarchy (achieved by fair or unfair means) tends unequal treatment to individuals.

(h). **Poverty and Stratification:** Surplus wealth or resources left with individuals become the source of any further economic order or stratification. The lower base of the pyramid is associated with poverty and maximum numbers..

(i). **Mobility:** Whether an individual can move across different strata of a society decides the social mobility. Vertical mobility refers to change in a person's social position with respect to the class or status. If a common factory laborer makes his way to the top management of the industry, his status changes, showing an upward mobility. Systems of stratification are classified into open or closed systems depending on their allowance of such mobility.

Characteristics of Social Stratification

The main characteristics of Social Stratification are described below.

1. Social-economic classification/ categorization: A stratified society is one with distinct social classes. *Most of the social stratification types are based on the social-economic classification.* This means the categorization of the society is done through two important considerations. *The social status and the economic status are considered mainly under the social-economic stratification.*

2. Universal: Another common characteristic of social stratification is that it is universal. This simply means that such social division concepts are found in almost all societies and cultures, sometimes deliberately and in other circumstances subconsciously. From developing countries to developed countries, the concept of social stratification is followed in various forms everywhere.

3. Hierarchical: Social stratification refers to the hierarchical society. Being hierarchical in nature, social stratification is reproduced from generation to generation. If a person belongs to a certain class, his/her generations will continue belonging to the same class. For example, some people will always be regarded to be more powerful than others.

4. Preserves the status quo: Categorization of people into different social classes is meant to ensure that the status quo is preserved.

5. Inequality in income, wealth distribution and social status: Some forms of social stratification refers to the inequality of income. This means if a person has a high capital income he/she falls in the upper class. Those with lower-income fall in the lower class and so on!

6. Unequal control over natural resources such as land: Social stratification results in the unequal control of natural resources. *For example, the high-class or the rich class people can own more land or other resources. On the other hand, the poor or the low-class people own fewer resources.*

7. Is in diverse forms: Social stratification is diverse in nature. This means the concept remains same with only differences in the name. Caste social stratification, slavery stratification, high-class, middle class, etc., are few such examples.

8. It has consequences: social stratification has consequences such as racial and class discrimination, unjust application of the law, and increasing income gap between the rich and the poor. It also leads to resentment between social classes.

9. It is purely social: It does not focus on natural abilities of an individual other than inequalities that have been caused by the society.

10. Inequality of opportunity: Some strata of society will usually have more opportunities for work, education and so on than others.

11. Stereotyping: Sometimes, people will stereotype the members of different social strata, cementing a particular image of them in the public's mind.

12. Dissatisfaction: The inequalities described above can lead to dissatisfaction, and even unrest, among the populace in a stratified society.

SOCIAL MOBILITY

What is Social Mobility?

Movement of people or categories of people through the hierarchical system of stratification; for example, from lower class to middle class. Horizontal mobility is when there is change of occupation or position of an individual, but not an accompanied change of class.

It is said that man is a social animal.

This refers to the interdependent behavior of human beings. Although living in groups, mankind has a tendency of still forming further sub-divisions in a given group. This inclination of further categorizing within a group is seen across cultures. Whatever may be the basis; division of labor, peculiar skills of a group, role of exercising authority, prestige, or any other criterion, social stratification exists as a very foundational principle in the working of a society. Let us understand its meaning first and then look at its types, characteristics, and examples.

Social mobility refers to the movement within the social structure, from one social position to another. It means a change in social status. All societies provide some opportunity for social mobility. But the societies differ from each other to extent in which individuals can move from one class or status level to another.

It is said that the greater the amount of social mobility, the more open the class structure. The concept of social mobility has fundamental importance in ascertaining the relative “openness” of a social structure. The nature, forms, direction and magnitude of social mobility depends on the nature and types of social stratification. Sociologists study social mobility in order to find out the relative ‘openness’ of a social structure.

Any group that improves its standard will also improve its social status. But the rate of social mobility is not uniform in all the countries. It differs from society to society from time to time. In India the rate of mobility is naturally low because of agriculture being the predominant occupation and the continuity of caste system as compared to the other countries of the world.

Types of Social Mobility:

In social stratification the movement occurs in three directions.

(a) From lower to higher, (b) From higher to lower (c) Between two positions at the same level.

Social mobility is of two types:

(i) Vertical mobility and (ii) Horizontal mobility

(i) Vertical mobility: It refers to the movement of people from one stratum to another or from one status to another. It brings changes in class, occupation and power. It involves movement

from lower to higher or higher to lower. There are two types of vertical mobility. (1) One is upward and other is (2) downward mobility.

When an individual moves from lower status to higher status, it is called upward mobility. For example, if the son of a peon joins a bank as an officer, it is said to be upward social mobility but if he loses the job due to any other reason or inefficiency, he is downwardly mobile from his previous job. So downward mobility takes place when a person moves down from one position to another and change his status negatively.

(ii) Horizontal Mobility: It refers to the movement of people from one social group to another situated on the same level. It means that the ranks of these two groups are not different. It indicates change in position without the change in status. For example, if a teacher leaves one school and joins another school or a bank officer leaves one branch to work in another or change of residence is the horizontal mobility.

Apart from the above two broad types of social stratification, there are two other types of social stratification in terms of dimension of time. They are:

(i) Inter-generational mobility: When changes in status occur from one generation to another, it is called intergenerational mobility. For example, if the son changes his status either by taking upon occupation of higher or lower rank with that of his father, there inter-generational mobility takes place.

Some condition tends to affect intergenerational mobility. They include the following:

- i. Differences between parents and off springs
- ii. Population change
- iii. Change in occupational structure

(ii) Intra-generational mobility: When changes in status occur within one generation, it is called intra-generational mobility. For example, the rise and fall in the occupational structure of a family which leads to change in its social status within one generation is called intra-generational mobility.